Human Evaluation in Text Simplification: Practical Recommendations for Including Persons with Cognitive and Intellectual Disabilities

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Abstract

Current evaluation practices for automatic text simplification (ATS) systems predominantly rely on automatic metrics or assessments by experts and crowdworkers, often excluding the intended end users due to overly heterogeneous population samples or difficulties in the recruitment process. Nonetheless, human evaluation involving primary target users is increasingly recognized as an essential component of ATS research. In this paper, we propose a set of research- and fieldwork-based recommendations covering ethics, recruitment, study design, data collection, and dissemination for the effective integration of end users with cognitive and intellectual disabilities in ATS evaluation processes.

1 Introduction

The automatic translation of standard language into simplified language varieties, such as Easy Language or Plain Language – referred to as automatic text simplification (ATS) – has attracted increasing interest in natural language processing (NLP) (Al-Thanyyan and Azmi, 2021; Stodden, 2026). While Plain Language aims to improve comprehensibility for a broad audience through reader-oriented communication, Easy Language follows stricter linguistic and textual rules and is primarily intended for persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities and other groups with limited reading skills (Maaß, 2020, 2026).

The human evaluation of ATS into Easy Language is associated with a number of challenges stemming from the diverse needs and characteristics of its primary target population. These challenges include difficulties in recruiting end users, ethical considerations related to their participation in research, heterogeneity in users' requirements, and preferences, as well as the limited suitability of certain evaluation methods for some target group members (cf. Becker et al., 2004; Wright et al., 2010). At the same time, the importance of involving primary target users in the evaluation of Easy Language texts has been repeatedly emphasized in the literature (Maaß, 2020; Štajner, 2021; Gooding, 2022; Carrer et al., 2024, 2026; Madina et al., 2024).

In this paper, we propose a set of research- and fieldwork-based practical recommendations for the effective integration of end users with cognitive and intellectual disabilities in ATS evaluation processes (see Figure 1 for an overview). Furthermore, we discuss potential applications of objective and subjective approaches to measuring reading comprehension. Our aim is to add to the NLP researcher's toolkit by outlining the challenges that might be encountered and the solutions that could be adopted. These recommendations were drawn up during four evaluation studies (cf. Säuberli et al., 2023; Säuberli et al., 2024; Carrer et al., 2024, 2026; Gao et al., 2025) carried out over the last four years in the context of a large-scale project as part of the Swiss Innovation Agency (Innosuisse) Flagship IICT (2022-2026).

1.1 Terminological note

According to the World Health Organization's International Classification of Functioning, Disability and Health (ICF; World Health Organization, 2001), disability arises from difficulties in one or more dimensions of human functioning (body functions, activities, and participation). This perspective marks a shift away from traditional medical

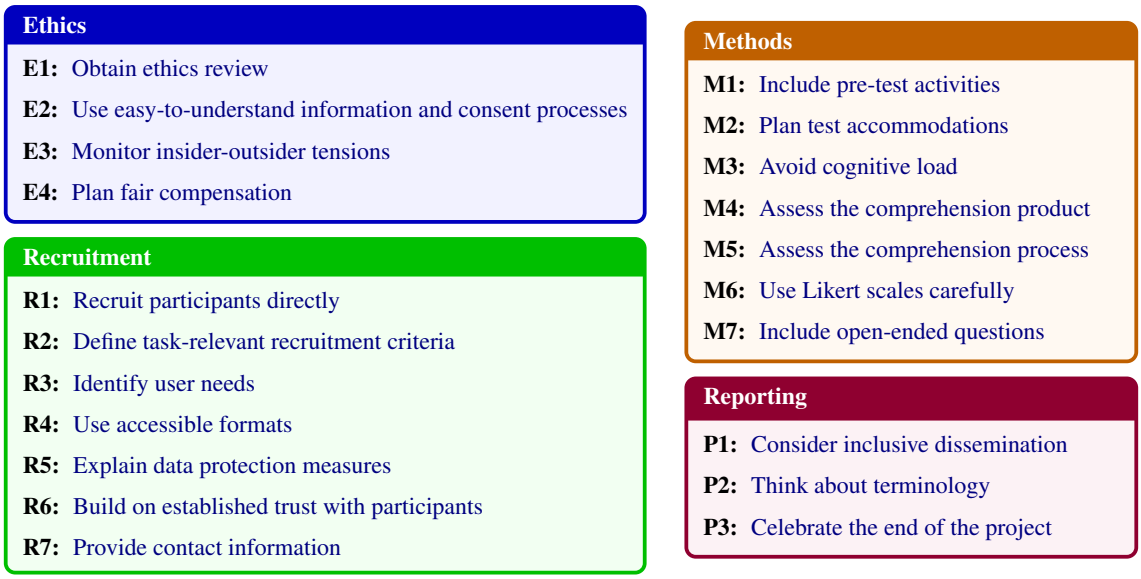


Figure 1: Clickable overview of our principles and recommendations

and biological models, which viewed disability primarily as an individual deficit. Instead, intellectual disability is increasingly understood through an ecological and multidimensional lens that recognizes the interaction between individuals and their environments. Within this framework, persons with disabilities are considered capable of participating successfully in typical settings when provided with appropriate supports (Wehmeyer et al., 2014).

Consistent with the three principal reference frameworks for intellectual disability (World Health Organization, 2001; Schalock et al., 2021; American Psychiatric Association, 2013), a diagnosis of intellectual disability requires significant and lifelong limitations in intellectual functioning and adaptive behavior, with onset before the age of 18. While intellectual disability refers to a specific diagnostic construct, the term 'cognitive disability' is used more broadly to describe "a situation of disadvantage experienced by individuals with cognitive abilities that differ from what is considered typical" (Cobigo et al., 2024, pp. 21-22). Cognitive disability can affect domains such as attention, executive functions, learning and memory, and language, and may arise from a range of conditions. These conditions may be present from birth, acquired through injury, or develop later in life as a result of illness (Cobigo et al., 2024).

In our evaluation studies, we recruited both target groups; in this article, we therefore use the term 'persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities'. Consistent with the observation of Nicholson et al. (2025), Cobigo et al. (2024) and Walmsley et al. (2018), we argue that inconsistent use of these terms can disadvantage people with cognitive and intellectual disabilities by resulting in inequitable access to and application of programs and policies. The adoption of unambiguous and standardized terminology would also facilitate the comparability and integration of research findings, thereby supporting the translation of research into practice and policy.

2 Background

2.1 Human Evaluation of Text Simplification

There is a general consensus that human evaluation is the most reliable way to measure the effectiveness of ATS systems (Alva-Manchego et al., 2020; Štajner, 2021; Gooding, 2022). Most commonly, this is implemented by asking experts or crowdworkers to rate the simplicity, fluency, and meaning preservation of simplified texts (Štajner and Nisioi, 2018; Mallinson et al., 2020; Stodden, 2021; Martin et al., 2022; Ryan et al., 2023; Stodden, 2026). Less commonly, actual comprehension is tested (Leroy et al., 2013, 2022; Fajardo et al., 2014; Alonzo et al., 2021; Agrawal and Carpuat, 2024; Beks van Raaij et al., 2024; Säuberli et al., 2024; Guidroz et al., 2025). Some works have analyzed reading behavior or user interactions as proxies for simplification quality (Rello et al., 2013a,b,c; Crossley et al., 2014; Saggion et al., 2015; Gooding et al., 2021). Qualitative approaches also exist (Martínez et al., 2024). However, only few studies include primary target users of Easy Language,

such as persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities (e.g., Huenerfauth et al., 2009; Saggion et al., 2015; Säuberli et al., 2024; Carrer et al., 2026; Gao et al., 2025).

Recently, we proposed a multidimensional approach to evaluating text simplification at document level involving end users, post-editors, and experts (Carrer et al., 2024, 2026). Our findings revealed distinct differences among stakeholders in how the simplified texts were perceived and understood, highlighting the value of a multi-stakeholder, human-centered approach to evaluating ATS models. Despite growing recognition of the importance of inclusive research practices, evaluation studies involving persons with cognitive and intellectual impairments are often regarded as excessively resource-intensive in terms of time and cost (Wickenden and Lopez Franco, 2021; Wickenden, 2024a). Such reluctance may arise from uncertainty, limited experience and resources, or the perception that the accommodations and expertise needed to engage this group are highly specialized (Wickenden and Lopez Franco, 2021). The present work seeks to address this knowledge gap by providing practical guidance for inclusive ATS evaluation.

2.2 Participatory and inclusive research

Inclusive research is a broad umbrella concept (Walmsley, 2001; Walmsley and Johnson, 2003). It refers to a range of research approaches, including 'participatory', 'emancipatory', and 'co-produced' research, which aim to address conventional power imbalances in knowledge production and promote the active participation of persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities (Nicholson et al., 2025; Nind and Vinha, 2014; Walmsley and Johnson, 2003). Grounded in disability rights principles (Charlton, 1998) and informed by social and human rights models of disability (Oliver et al., 2012; Wickenden and Lopez Franco, 2021), inclusive research is often guided by the ethos of "Nothing about us, without us" (Aspis, 2000). This perspective recognizes that persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities can contribute meaningfully to all stages of the research process, thereby strengthening the validity and relevance of research and evaluation while helping to minimize potential biases (cf. Ghaderi et al., 2025). Consequently, inclusive research is understood as research conducted *with* or *by* persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities, rather than research conducted *on* them (Nind, 2014).

According to Wright et al.'s (2010) model, participation in research should not be an 'either/or' option, but rather a dynamic and progressive process that can take different forms depending on the practical circumstances of the project and the living conditions of the community partners, ranging from a non-participatory level (instrumentalization, instruction), to a pre-participation stage (information, consultation, involvement), to a level of actual participation (shared decision-making, decision-making authority), and finally to levels beyond participation (community-owned initiatives). In many cases, only preliminary stages of participation may be feasible (cf. also Wright, 2014).

The growing adoption of participatory research has led to an increasing body of literature documenting its findings (cf. Ghaderi et al., 2025; Nicholson et al., 2025). However, as Ghaderi et al. (2025) discuss, these publications often provide insufficient methodological detail on how collaboration was implemented in practice, offering limited insight into the strengths and limitations of the strategies employed. This paper addresses this gap and focuses on end users' evaluation at a pre-participation stage, specifically on participants with cognitive and intellectual disabilities contribute to the assessment of the outcomes, strengths and failures of ATS systems.

3 Principles and practical recommendations

3.1 Ethics

Participatory research approaches raise a number of ethical considerations (Wilson et al., 2018), particularly by challenging conventional requirements around informed consent, anonymity and confidentiality (Bussu et al., 2021).

E1: Obtain ethics review

ATS studies involving end users with cognitive and intellectual disabilities should undergo an ethics review process and obtain approval by an institutional ethics committee. An ethics statement should include consideration of the potential risks to the target population and state how these will be mitigated. For example, an ethics review can help identify and mitigate risks of participant distress or undue cognitive burden by ensuring that testing procedures are appropriately paced, accessible, and allow participants to withdraw or take breaks when

needed. An ethics review can also help protect participants' privacy by assessing how pseudonymized data are collected, stored, accessed, and ultimately deleted.

E2: Use easy-to-understand information and consent processes

Information and consent processes need to be carefully adapted to ensure that participants understand what they are agreeing to. Using alternative formats such as written information in Easy Language is recommended (Wickenden, 2024b; Nind, 2014) (cf. example in Appendix A). Accessible formats should be validated by one or more representatives of the end user group(s) before being administered. Consent should be an ongoing process so that individuals can easily withdraw if they wish to.

Normally, participants confirm for themselves whether they are legally authorized to sign the informed consent form independently. Alternatively, the local organizations of persons with disability (OPDs[1]) or self-advocacy associations (cf. Section 3.2) partnering with the researchers could assist by providing the relevant information.

E3: Monitor insider-outsider tensions

Participatory practices in research seek to bridge the divide between researchers (outsiders) and study participants (insiders) (cf. Kogen, 2025). Nevertheless, insider-outsider tensions can emerge when partners hold differing assumptions about the research process, including contrasting understandings of the researcher's role or perceptions that external researchers stand to benefit most from participation (Minkler, 2004). In our case, this tension was particularly evident in one participant's persistent questions regarding the ultimate aims of the research project and the potential benefits that participation might provide for themselves and their peers. Expectations regarding the roles and responsibilities of researchers and participants should be discussed transparently and continuously reviewed and renegotiated (cf. Banks et al., 2013; Wilson et al., 2018).

E4: Plan fair compensation

[1]An OPD is a non-governmental organization or association that is led, directed, and governed by persons who identify as persons with disabilities.

Regardless of the research context, participants' contributions should be appropriately recognized; when implementing inclusion principles in the research process, this entails providing equitable and meaningful compensation (Rabinowitz et al., 2024). If participants incur travel expenses, compensation should account for these as well. As part of our evaluation studies, participants were rewarded with department store gift cards (one card per session). In inclusive research projects involving higher levels of collaboration (cf. Section 2.2), co-researchers may be formally compensated on an hourly-basis, subject to regulations concerning disability insurance or other applicable social welfare legislation. Researchers should be aware that administrative and legal barriers may hinder formal payment for persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities and arrangements should be considered on a case-by-case basis.

3.2 Recruitment

3.2.1 How to build trust in target users

As often reported in the literature (cf. Becker et al., 2004; Wright et al., 2010), recruiting persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities poses considerable challenges. Users' motivation to participate in research may be influenced by several factors including unfamiliarity with the research process. Participatory approaches commonly assume that members of the target population possess the confidence and ability to express and advocate for their interests. However, for many socially disadvantaged groups, these abilities may need to be developed and supported before they can meaningfully engage in participatory processes. As a result, a willingness or desire to participate cannot always be assumed (Wright et al., 2010). In our evaluation studies, the fluctuating availability of recruited participants due to health reasons, professional commitments or loss of interest also proved challenging.

Trust is essential in recruitment processes. A commonly reported challenge in participatory research is in fact the absence of trust between researchers and community partners (Armstrong et al., 2023). This may result from prior research that offered little or no tangible benefit to the community and failed to communicate study findings back to participants (cf. Section 3.4). To prevent or counterbalance these negative effects, the following recommendations are proposed (cf. cf. Wickenden,

2024a,b; cf. also Section 3.2.2):

R1: Recruit participants directly

Direct recruitment through physical proximity and face-to-face interaction is essential for building and sustaining trust (Armstrong et al., 2023). Close collaboration with local OPDs, self-advocacy associations or community programs is equally important for establishing rapport. Local administrations often maintain online directories of organizations active in the disability sector, which can serve as a useful starting point for identifying potential recruitment partners.

When recruiting participants for the first time, it is advisable to conduct initial meetings in collaboration with a trusted staff member or facilitator from the partner organization. In addition, peer effects should not be underestimated: combining more experienced co-researchers with newcomers can be particularly beneficial. In our studies, it proved helpful for peers to explain their own roles in the evaluation process, as this boosted confidence and motivation among other potential participants ("if they can do it, so can I").

R2: Define task-relevant recruitment criteria

During recruitment, embracing and accepting diversity is key, as is avoiding excluding potential participants based on subjective judgments about how they might or might not contribute. Instead, recruitment criteria should be guided by the functional requirements of the research protocol: researchers should identify the minimum skills or experiences necessary to complete the study tasks – for example, the ability to read the materials or use a touchscreen device – and use these requirements consistently when determining eligibility. In line with the social model of disability, our studies did not recruit participants on the basis of diagnostic categories but instead sought to minimize unnecessary barriers to participation (cf. R3 below).

R3: Identify user needs

In recruiting participants, any requirements for support or accommodation (e.g., producing digitally accessible materials) should be identified, and the associated costs should be accounted for in the budget. Different types of barriers (e.g., physical, communicative, attitudinal or structural) could prevent participation, some of which might be invisible or difficult to spot. It is essential to verify requirements rather than making assumptions about what is needed; for instance, this may include arranging to meet a participant at the train station and accompanying them to the research venue.

3.2.2 How to communicate with target users

When visiting associations or groups and proactively recruiting potential participants, consider the following aspects:

R4: Use accessible formats

Visual materials and oral presentations in accessible formats (e.g., fact sheets or PowerPoint presentations in Easy Language) should be used to explain the purpose of the study and what participation would involve. Ideally, information materials should provide a sample of the actual reading material used in the study, allowing participants to form a realistic expectation of what the task will entail. Invitations and information should also highlight the measures taken to ensure disability inclusion and reinforce that all individuals are welcome.

R5: Explain data protection measures

Participants may be reluctant to provide sociodemographic data. Researchers must be transparent about the purposes of data collection. The pseudonymization of data must be explained and explicitly ensured, both in writing (consent form) and verbally, before and after recruitment.

R6: Build on established trust with participants

Similar to Armstrong et al. (2023), we observed that affiliation with a well-known local university – one the participants may already heard of – can enhance their trust in the institution. Opening the doors of university buildings and organizing informal gatherings before or during testing sessions can substantially contribute to building trust.

To maintain trust over time and encourage continued recruitment for later projects, regular face-to-face engagement is particularly valuable (cf. Armstrong et al., 2023).

It is furthermore important to clarify and emphasize that participants will be compensated for their time and effort (cf. Section 3.1). At the same time, expectations regarding responsibilities – such as punctuality and remaining for the agreed duration

of sessions – should be explicitly stated, reflecting that participation constitutes paid work with corresponding obligations.

R7: Provide contact information

A designated contact person should be identified, and all relevant contact details should be made available to participants in the informed consent form and/or other information materials.

3.3 Methods

3.3.1 Preparing a test session

When designing test sessions, particular attention should be paid to ensuring compliance with ethical standards:

M1: Include pre-test activities

On the day of the test, a succinct oral presentation of the project can be provided again. If additional researchers are present who have not previously met the participants, appropriate introductions should be made, including a clear explanation of who they are and what their role in the study involves. Furthermore, a step-by-step explanation of what the participants might expect during the test should be followed by a reiterated understanding that participant could ask questions and leave the test at any time.

Researchers are advised to obtain informed consent in a session conducted prior to the test. This approach provides sufficient time to explain the project aims and address any questions or concerns participants may have. It also offers a valuable opportunity to administer a pre-test questionnaire for the collection of sociodemographic and other relevant background information (e.g., reading habits). In our evaluation studies, no sensitive information (e.g., diagnoses or specifics about participants' disabilities) were collected.

M2: Plan test accommodations

Despite reported limitations associated with multiple-choice testing formats (cf. Section 3.3.2 below), Prosser and Bromley (2012, p. 112) argue that multiple-choice questions may still be used appropriately, if the researcher "takes time to explore whether the person can understand the question". Read-aloud accommodations – e.g., oral presentation of test items – could therefore be offered (cf. Carrer, 2021). Universal and/or individual test accommodations are those changes intended to remove "construct irrelevant barriers" (Sireci et al., 2005, p. 457), enable persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities to better demonstrate knowledge and consequently lead to more valid interpretations of their test scores.

M3: Avoid cognitive load

A testing session should be designed to avoid inducing cognitive overload in participants. In our evaluation studies, this involved limiting each session to a maximum of four texts of approximately 250 words each, with each text followed by four multiple-choice comprehension questions (cf. M4 in Section 3.3.2).

Flexible breaks should be permitted to allow participants with health conditions or those who tire easily to rest and move around as needed (Wickenden, 2024b). Refreshments should be provided as required.

3.3.2 Testing comprehension

In this section, we present and discuss a selection of methods used to assess end users' comprehension processes – the cognitive activities involved in understanding written language – and comprehension products, which represent the outcome of that understanding (Bock and Pappert, 2023, p. 172). Some of these methods, such as selected-response tasks, are drawn directly from our empirical experience; others, like constructed-response tasks, are proposed for future work as a meaningful tool for data triangulation. To ensure the statistical validity of these methods, the required sample size can be estimated from expected effect size and variability, with pilot studies providing additional guidance. In general, greater response variability is expected in heterogeneous participant groups, such as persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities (Bock and Pappert, 2023, p. 195). Although this often calls for larger samples, limited participant availability may constrain recruitment; in such cases, reducing the number of independent variables (e.g., the number of compared ATS systems) and using less variability-sensitive experimental paradigms (e.g., comprehension tasks with discrete choices, picture-matching tasks, cloze tasks, self-paced untimed reading with comprehension check) may be advisable (Bock and Pappert, 2023, p. 196). To explore group-specific differences, two cohorts from

different populations (e.g., persons with and without cognitive and intellectual disabilities) can be recruited.

M4: Assess the comprehension product

In our latest evaluation study (Carrer et al., 2026), we compared the comprehensibility of source texts and three corresponding simplified versions and measured (a) end-users' actual comprehension using multiple-choice questions, and (b) perceived difficulty using Likert-style ratings (cf. Section 3.3.3). For each experimental text, four multiple-choice questions were developed (four response options, one correct answer).

Administering multiple-choice questionnaires to persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities may increase the risk of response biases, such as acquiescence (i.e., the tendency to agree with or answer 'yes', regardless of the content of the question; cf. Prosser and Bromley, 2012). Acquiescence often reflects inappropriate questioning, for example when questions are too long or syntactically complex (Finlay and Lyons, 2001). Questionnaire items should be brief (ideally no more than 12 words), unambiguous, and independent of one another. They should also follow principles of appropriate density and orderly layout (Dörnyei and Dewaele, 2023) to enhance accessibility and respondent motivation. In addition, items should be answerable without requiring prior world knowledge, while not being solvable through world knowledge alone. Content validation and pilot testing are recommended before test administration.

Human evaluations could include broader qualitative measures to counterbalance the above-reported format limitations. Post-test interviews involving comprehension questions, for instance, could be used to triangulate test scores and assess factual and contextual knowledge acquired as well as respondents' individual integration of a text into their knowledge system (i.e., deeper comprehension of the text) (Bock and Pappert, 2023, p. 218, based on Christmann 2009).

Free or structured recall tasks, in which respondents retell the meaning of a text as accurately and as completely as possible, can also be used to gain insights into individual representations of textual meaning. Depending on the research focus, data can be analyzed quantitatively through summative content analysis, or qualitatively via deductive and inductive coding (Bock and Pappert, 2023, p. 219, based on Christmann 2009).

M5: Assess the comprehension process

Our experience suggests that tablets are well suited for administering reading comprehension tests. Indeed, the vast majority of participants in our evaluation studies reported daily use of touchscreen devices. Data were collected using a custom-developed mobile app (Säuberli et al., 2023), which enabled participants to read and rate the texts (cf. Section 3.3.3) and complete the comprehension tasks. The app recorded both the initial reading time and the response time for each comprehension question. Reading times may serve as an indirect indicator of how carefully participants read the texts before rating them.

Concurrent think-aloud protocols can provide insight into cognitive processes (e.g., reading strategies) by asking participants to verbalize their thoughts, emotions, and perceptions during reading. However, this method imposes considerable cognitive and linguistic demands and may therefore be challenging for the target population (Bock and Pappert, 2023, pp. 234-235).

3.3.3 Probing subjective perception

The subjective perception of texts is an important aspect of evaluation, as it can influence the reader's motivation and attitude towards reading the text.

M6: Use Likert scales carefully

Likert-scale ratings are by far the most popular method to measure perceived difficulty for ATS evaluation. Such ratings have also been applied in user studies with persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities (Huenerfauth et al., 2009). However, response biases need to be carefully considered when applying this approach (cf. Section 3.3.2). Hartley and MacLean Jr. (2006, p. 816) found that "adolescents and adults with [intellectual disabilities] have a tendency to choose the most positive response alternative in Likert-type scales". Moreover, in our own studies, we found that difficulty ratings often do not correlate well with comprehension test results (Säuberli et al., 2024), suggesting a mismatch between subjective perception and comprehension.

To facilitate the understanding of the scale, we found the user interface design to play an important role (Säuberli et al., 2023). For instance, the

meaning of the different levels can be indicated redundantly using textual descriptors, emoticons, and colors at the same time. However, researchers should be aware that the interpretation of facial expressions, including emoticons, can differ between individuals (Zashchirinskaia et al., 2020; Taylor et al., 2024). Nevertheless, the use of graphical depictions instead of (or in addition to) text can reduce cognitive load.

M7: Include open-ended questions

Hartley and MacLean Jr. (2006, p. 823) mention that the validity of Likert scales can be enhanced by asking clarifying questions or prompts like *'Tell me more about it'*. A qualitative component not only ensures that opinions are accurately reflected, but it can also provide explanations for *why* something is considered easier or more difficult. Given the heterogeneity of the target user group, researchers may also expect high diversity in what the readers consider to be difficult. Particularly when the number of study participants is small, open-ended questions can provide more valuable information than pre-defined scales with potentially inconsistent interpretations.

3.4 Reporting

Researchers should consider including dissemination of findings to the target community as part of the study design.

P1: Consider inclusive dissemination

A summary report of the main findings in Easy Language may be disseminated through partner associations to participants and other stakeholders with an interest in the results. Plain Language summaries published alongside journal articles (Stoll et al., 2022; St. John et al., 2022), or multi-modal online resources incorporating pictures, icons, visual imagery, and graphic illustrations in line with Universal Design for Learning principles (Lowrey and Smith, 2018; Persson et al., 2015) can enhance the accessibility and usability of research information (cf. Parent-Johnson and Duncan, 2024).

Community dissemination may also involve formats that move beyond a top-down, unidirectional transfer of information. For instance, interactive presentations (McDavitt et al., 2016) that include opportunities for discussion and feedback can facilitate two-way dialogue, minimize the risk of unintentionally reinforcing stigmatizing narratives against the target population and, ultimately, strengthen community-academic partnerships.

P2: Think about terminology

Researchers should be aware that words can intentionally or unintentionally reflect bias or patronizing attitudes toward persons with disabilities (Hanson et al., 2015). Disability-related terminology should therefore be used thoughtfully and transparently, recognizing that preferred terms vary across languages, countries, and communities. For example, German-speaking self-advocates often reject the label *geistig behindert* ('intellectually disabled') and instead prefer the term *Menschen mit Lernschwierigkeiten* ('persons with learning difficulties') (Bredel and Maaß, 2016, pp. 138-139). Similarly, self-advocates in England may prefer the term *person with learning difficulty*. However, in mainstream educational contexts in England, 'learning difficulty' is commonly understood to refer to a 'specific learning difficulty', such as dyslexia or dispraxia, rather than intellectual disability (Cluley, 2018). Preferences also differ with respect to person-first language (e.g., *persons with intellectual disabilities*) and identity-first language (e.g., *intellectually disabled people*) (cf. Dunn and Andrews, 2015). Such variation underscores the importance of avoiding assumptions that terminology is universally understood or accepted.

To promote clarity and facilitate comparison across studies, researchers may choose to align their terminology with established international reference frameworks (cf. Section 1.1) and apply this terminology consistently throughout their work. At the same time, our experience suggests that inclusive research calls for considering how participants describe and identify themselves. Researchers may therefore wish to negotiate terminology with the target population and adopt the terms preferred by participants, while explicitly defining these terms in publications and relating them to internationally recognized concepts. This approach balances respect for participants' self-identification with the need for terminological mono-referentiality and consistency in scientific communication.

P3: Celebrate the end of the project

Researchers may consider combining interactive dissemination events (as described above) with end-

of-project celebratory activities to create a lasting impression. We believe that hosting the event at the partner association could also increase visibility among other residents, including potential future participants, by raising awareness of the research and opportunities for involvement. Alternatively, hosting the closing event at the university could provide an opportunity to acknowledge participants' contributions within the academic setting, while also raising awareness among university staff of the value of inclusive research practices. Such an approach would be consistent with the principles of the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UN-CRPD).

4 Conclusions

Human evaluation involving primary target users is increasingly recognized as an essential component of ATS research. Nevertheless, researchers may hesitate to involve persons with cognitive and intellectual disabilities, as participatory studies are often perceived as requiring substantial time, resources, and specialized expertise. This paper has argued that many of these barriers can be mitigated through careful planning and the adoption of inclusive research practices. Drawing on experience from a series of evaluation studies, we have presented practical recommendations covering ethics, recruitment, study design, data collection, and dissemination.

Managing power dynamics between academic researchers, practitioners, and community partners remains an ongoing challenge, requiring continuous self-reflection, open communication, and the willingness to renegotiate roles and expectations throughout the research process. At the same time, participation should be understood as a progressive continuum that can begin with pre-participatory forms of involvement and gradually evolve toward higher levels of collaboration where appropriate. Importantly, ethically sound human evaluation conducted at earlier stages of this continuum can already produce valuable scientific evidence, while also laying the foundation for stronger community partnerships and greater participant empowerment in future work.

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Limitations

We acknowledge that inclusive evaluation studies, and inclusive research processes more broadly, require context-sensitive approaches rather than a one-size-fits-all model. Various contextual and practical factors may give rise to tensions between the commitment to involving persons with intellectual and cognitive disabilities as extensively as possible in evaluation teams and processes, and the realities of implementation in practice (Ghaderi et al., 2025). Among the most significant challenges are resource constraints, especially the time and funding required to design and implement inclusive research, which may, in some cases, preclude the conduct of an inclusive research project altogether. Small and highly heterogeneous samples may constitute a further challenge, and the recommendations advanced in this article, while effective for our particular study population, may not be equally applicable across different samples or research contexts. At the same time, our recommendations are intended to underscore the importance of incorporating the resources required for inclusive evaluation into project planning and initial budgeting, thereby positioning inclusiveness as a standard component of research practice rather than an optional addition. Furthermore, while we recognize that our recommendations are informed by experiences with target groups situated within a western, industrialized, and democratic context, and that this contextual specificity may limit their transferability, their integration into research and evaluation practice may nevertheless provide a reasonable starting point for adapting inclusive approaches to different research settings and populations.

Lay Summary

Background: Many people find written information difficult to understand. This can make it harder to access important information about health, work, education, or everyday life. One approach to making written information easier to understand is Easy Language. Easy Language is designed especially for people who may have difficulties understanding written information, including some people with

cognitive and intellectual disabilities. Researchers are now developing computer systems that can automatically make texts easier to understand. This is called automatic text simplification. Researchers often test automatically simplified texts by asking experts or members of the general public to rate them. However, these tests do not always include the people who are most likely to use Easy Language. Including the target group can make the development and testing of accessible information more inclusive, while giving participants an opportunity to contribute their experiences and perspectives.

Research question: How can people with cognitive and intellectual disabilities be effectively and respectfully included in the evaluation of automatically simplified texts?

Findings: The authors developed recommendations based on experience from several studies involving people with cognitive and intellectual disabilities. They recommend making research information and consent procedures easy to understand, protecting participants' privacy, and providing fair compensation. To build trust and support participation, researchers should recruit participants directly, identify their needs and provide appropriate support. During testing, researchers should combine simple comprehension questions with other methods, such as asking people to explain the text in their own words or describe what they found difficult. Participants should also be able to ask questions, take breaks, and use appropriate accommodations. Finally, researchers should share their findings with participants and communities in accessible formats.

Who benefits from the findings? The recommendations can help researchers involve people with cognitive and intellectual disabilities more effectively in the evaluation of automatically simplified texts. They may also support more inclusive research practices in other fields. However, there is no single approach that suits everyone; methods should be adapted to the needs of participants, communities, and research settings.

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A Example of Easy-to-understand Consent Form

Consent Form

About this study

The study is titled: "Comprehensibility of Simplified Texts."
It is a research project.

It is done by:
[Name of Principal Investigator]

She works at:
[Name of Institution]

Before you take part

We need your consent for the study.
That is why you must sign this consent form.

By signing, you say:

- I have read the information
- I understand the information
- I agree to take part in the study

What data we collect

[Name of Principal Investigator] and her team collect **data** about you.

For example:

- your name
- your age
- your answers in the study

How we protect your data

Your name and your answers are kept separate.

- Your answers are stored using a code.
- Your name is stored in a separate list.
- The list links your name to your code.

Only these people can see the list:
[Names of Researchers in the Project Team]

They work at:
[Name of Institution]

They are not allowed to share this list with anyone else.

Who can see your data

Only the researchers can see your data.
They keep your data safe.

This means:

- No one else can read your data
- No one else can take your data
- Your data is stored securely.

After the project ends

The project ends in:
[Month/Year]

After the project ends:

- The list that links names and codes is deleted
- Your data becomes fully anonymous
- No one can trace your answers back to you

How long we store your data

We store your data for at least 10 years.

During this time:

- Your data is used only for research
- Your data is not used for other purposes
- If results are published, your name is never shown

Your rights

Taking part is voluntary.

This means:

- You can decide if you want to take part
- You can change your mind at any time

If you change your mind:

- You can say: “I do not want to take part anymore.”
- You do not need to explain why
- There are no disadvantages for you

If the study is still running:

- Your data will be deleted

If the study is already finished:

- Your data is already anonymous
- It cannot be linked back to you

To stop taking part, contact:
[Name of Principal Investigator]

Please confirm:

☐ I received an information sheet.
☐ Someone explained the study to me.
☐ I had time to ask questions.
☐ I could understand what the study is about.
☐ I have no more questions.

Your decision

I want to take part in the study:

☐ Yes ☐ No

You will receive a copy of this signed form.

Signatures

Place, Date: _____
Participant name: _____
Participant signature: _____
Place, Date: _____
Signature of Principal Investigator: _____

Contact

If you have questions, contact:
[Contact details of Principal Investigator]

Complaints

If you want to complain about the study, you can contact:
[Contact details of Ethics Committee Representative]